Zhongxian, PRC's ambassador to India, had submitted a three-point proposal that clearly said Tibet could either accept Chinese sovereignty peacefully or face the military might of the People's Liberation Army.

B. N. Mullik, the head of India's Intelligence Bureau (IB) at the time, had warned the Government of India that China would almost certainly invade Tibet and had prodded Nehru to consider the option of armed intervention should the situation arise. Accordingly, a meeting was held in the office of the foreign secretary, K. P. S Menon. Along with defence minister, Baldev Singh, and the Commander-in-Chief of the Indian Army, General K. M. Cariappa, India's first ambassador to China, Sardar K. M. Panikkar, was also present.

Mullik argued that by letting the Chinese have their way in Tibet, the equation on India's northern border would change dramatically. The IB chief stated that although neither the United States nor Britain would directly get involved, India could count on their covert support. The Americans, he told the group, had promised air support and were willing to airlift an Indian brigade to Chamdo in Eastern Tibet. Even if preliminary steps were put into place, Chinese Intelligence would surely pass it on to Chairman Mao who would then perhaps think twice before launching troops into Tibet. When Nehru asked Cariappa for his views, he categorically stated that military intervention on behalf of the Tibetans was beyond the capability of the Indian Army.

Cariappa said he simply did not have any troops to spare. If he had no choice but to send troops, only one infantry battalion (approximately 600 men) could be spared from Jammu and Kashmir. This battalion, given the fact that no Indian troops were trained to fight and survive at high altitudes, would have to be inducted into the Chumbi Valley (adjacent to Sikkim on the border with Bhutan and Tibet) over Jelep-la and Nathu-la, and at best one company (about 120 men) could be maintained at Gyantse (in Tibet). Given that the Communist Chinese had the experience of fighting in extremely cold conditions and were better armed owing to the vast quantities of US weapons that were left behind by the retreating Chinese Nationalist Army, the general felt Mullik was being too optimistic. Nehru, who had embarked on a deliberate policy of bringing China onto the world stage, then let it be known that he was not willing to intervene militarily. The Indian prime minister also felt any military offensive by India would severely impact her standing in the eyes of the world. Mullik was to write